

Team Cappin — PlayLocal

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Project Description

PlayLocal is a location-based social platform for organizing local pickup sports. The primary goal is to foster community and consistent participation by solving the most common problems in casual sports: reliability, safety, and finding a welcoming group.

As lifestyles become more digital and isolated, many people seek low-pressure ways to stay active and meet new people. The biggest barriers are often logistical uncertainty (Will enough people show up?) and social anxiety (Will the group be welcoming and safe?). PlayLocal addresses these issues by creating a platform that prioritizes reliability and positive social connections. We are committed to building an inclusive and safe environment, ensuring everyone can find a group where they feel comfortable and respected.

Core Features

Development will be strictly phased based on technical and product-safety dependencies. The Minimum Viable Product (MVP) will deliver a complete, end-to-end player reliability loop and the essential tools for user safety. Post-MVP enhancements will build upon this stable and secure foundation.

MVP Features (Term Deliverable)

The goal is to launch a viable and safe platform that accurately tracks player attendance and allows users to report misconduct.

- **1. Foundational Systems: Profile, Safety, and Identity**
 - **User Account System:** The core system for user identity and authentication.
 - **Basic Player Profile:** A minimal profile displaying a user's chosen **Self-Rated Intensity** ("Beginner," "Casual," or "Competitive") and their **Reliability Score**.
 - **Basic Moderation System:** A discreet "Report Issue" button on user profiles and game pages, and a simple backend queue for administrators to review.
- **2. Core Loop: The Game Lifecycle & Reliability Engine**
 - **Game Creation & Discovery:** An organizer can create an event with essential details (sport, location, time, intensity). Other users can find these events and RSVP.
 - **Notification System:** A minimal system, such as an in-app prompt or automated email, that alerts the organizer when a game ends and directs them to confirm attendance. This is a critical component to ensure the reliability loop closes.
 - **Organizer-Confirmed Attendance:** Post-game, the organizer is presented with the RSVP roster. Their only task is to uncheck the names of any no-shows and

submit the final list. This action serves as the primary source of truth for attendance and is designed to be difficult to game.

- **Reliability Score Calculation:** The data from the organizer-confirmed roster is used to automatically update the Reliability Score for any player marked as a no-show.

Post-MVP Enhancements (Future Work)

These features will be developed after the core MVP is validated as stable and safe. They are categorized by the systems they depend upon.

- **1. Social Graph & Enhanced Trust Signals**
 - **Friending System:** The foundational ability for users to send and accept connection requests. This is a prerequisite for all subsequent social features.
 - **Active Connections & Mutuals:** Profile metrics calculated based on recent game participation with users on one's friends list. This requires the **Friending System** to be in place.
 - **Organizer Endorsements ("Organizer's Pick"):** A scarce public award for good sportsmanship, which leverages the post-game prompt established in the MVP's **Organizer-Confirmed Attendance** flow.
- **2. Advanced Game Management & Community Tools**
 - **Reputation-Gated Games:** An organizer can set a minimum **Reliability Score** as a requirement to join, directly leveraging the core MVP metric.
 - **Community-Specific Game Filters:** An expansion of the MVP's **Game Creation** system to include filters like "Women-Only" or "Over-40s."
- **3. Communication & Engagement Features**
 - **Integrated Group Chat:** A real-time chat room for each game. This depends on integrating a new real-time messaging infrastructure.
 - **Shared Photo Album:** A collaborative photo album for each event.
- **4. Organizer Trust & Reliability System**
 - **Organizer Quality Score (OQS):** This feature introduces a reciprocal trust metric for organizers based on objective performance data. It is a single, weighted score calculated from metrics like Game Completion Rate and Repeat Player Rate. For transparency, the calculation method will be explained within an in-app info card.
 - **New Organizer Onboarding:** A structured path to mitigate the "cold-start" problem, featuring a provisional status for an organizer's first few games and a one-time boost for users who have a high personal Reliability Score as a player.

Novelty and Disruption

PlayLocal's innovation is its proactive integration of trust and safety features into the core product loop.

- **Proactive Trust & Safety System:** Unlike platforms with reactive moderation, we build safety into the discovery and reputation systems. Private reporting and features like "Women-Only" games allow communities to self-police and form safely, preventing issues before they escalate.
- **Reputation Built on Reliability:** We shift the primary user metric from ambiguous "skill" to objective "reliability." This directly incentivizes the number one behavior required for successful pickup games: showing up.
- **Empowering Inclusive Communities:** By providing tools for users to create their own safe spaces, we lower the barrier to entry for demographics often underserved or intimidated by traditional sports environments.

Risk Mitigation

- **User Safety & Liability:** The private reporting system is the primary tool for flagging users for moderation review, allowing for rapid removal of bad actors.
- **Privacy:** All profiles are private to registered users. Photo sharing is opt-in per event. Game locations are hidden until a user's RSVP is confirmed. The system is designed to enforce transparency for core reputation signals to ensure consistency. The full friends list is permanently private. Only the calculated "active" counts and mutuals are public.
- **Community Fragmentation:** Offering "Community-Specific" games could split the user base in areas with low density. To mitigate this, the app will monitor game-fill rates and can suggest to organizers that they broaden the audience if their game is unlikely to reach capacity.
- **Reputation System Gaming:** The system is designed to be resistant to gaming. Reliability is objective. Active Connections require real-world participation. 'Organizer's Picks' are scarce and publicly attributed, discouraging abuse.
- **Organizer Unreliability:** An organizer who cancels games, misrepresents event details, or violates community guidelines poses a significant threat to user trust. The MVP's private reporting system serves as the primary reactive tool, allowing players to flag incidents for administrative review. This is systemically mitigated post-MVP with the introduction of the Organizer Quality Score (OQS), an objective metric based on game completion and repeat player rates.

Team Organization & Workflow

Project work will be organized and assigned on a per-feature basis using User Stories (US). All development tasks will be defined as User Stories and maintained in a prioritized backlog. Team members will be dynamically assigned to these stories, either individually or in small ad-hoc groups, based on the immediate project priorities.

The entire workflow will be managed via GitHub. Each User Story will correspond to a GitHub Issue. Development will take place on dedicated feature branches, and code will be integrated into the main branch through Pull Requests that require peer review. This methodology ensures that team efforts are consistently aligned with the most critical product goals for the MVP and allows for flexible resource allocation as the project progresses.

Competition

Search terms: “outdoor games app”, “organize pickup sports RSVP waitlist”, “sports team management app availability”, “pickup sports platform”, “sports community app team assignments”, “pickup games near you app”, “sports event organizer app waitlist”, “adult pickup league app”

Number of pages examined: 28

Direct Competitors (Specialized Sports Platforms)

Competitor 1: OpenSports (opensports.ca)

- **What they offer:** OpenSports is a powerful event management platform for sports organizers, handling everything from pickup games to complex leagues and tournaments. Its key features are logistical and financial, including robust tools for RSVPs, waitlists, and payment collection.
- **Why PlayLocal is still novel:** OpenSports is built for the *event organizer*. PlayLocal is built for the *community*. While OpenSports excels at managing the logistics of a roster, it lacks the tools to manage the social health and reliability of the players within it. Our novelty comes from our integrated reputation system. The objective Reliability Score and positive Sportsmanship Endorsements are core features designed to build a foundation of trust and accountability, which are absent in transaction-focused platforms like OpenSports.

Competitor 2: Pickupgames.app

- **What they offer:** This platform is a streamlined discovery tool focused on answering the question, “Where is a game near me?” It provides a map-based interface for users to find and join local pickup games with minimal friction.
- **Why PlayLocal is still novel:** Pickupgames.app solves the problem of discovery, but not the more critical problems of trust and reliability. A user can find a game, but has no information on whether the confirmed players will actually show up or if the group will be welcoming. PlayLocal’s novelty lies in the layer of trust we build on top of discovery. The Reliability Score provides confidence in the headcount, while Sportsmanship

Endorsements and community-specific filters like "Women-Only" provide confidence in the social environment.

Competitor 3: ENDALGO (endalgo.com)

- **What they offer:** ENDALGO is a group management tool for existing sports clubs and teams. It provides a suite of features for internal organization, including scheduling, communication, and managing member availability.
- **Why PlayLocal is still novel:** ENDALGO provides logistical tools for a pre-existing, trusted group. PlayLocal is designed to build new, trusted communities from the ground up. Our key differentiator is the portable and objective reputation system. An organizer on ENDALGO must manually track and police unreliable members. An organizer on PlayLocal can simply set a minimum Reliability Score for their game. This reputation follows users across the platform, creating a persistent signal of trust that is essential for forming new, healthy communities.

Indirect and Legacy Competitors (Generic Platforms)

Competitor 4: Meetup and Facebook Groups

- **What they offer:** These are the incumbent giants of general community organization. With massive, established user bases, they serve as the default platform for organizing local activities, including sports, through their event and group functionalities.
- **Why PlayLocal is still novel:** These platforms are generic, blunt instruments for a specialized problem. Their core systems are fundamentally misaligned with the needs of pickup sports.
 1. **Unreliable RSVPs:** An RSVP on Facebook or Meetup is a low-commitment "like" button. There is no system to track attendance and no consequence for no-shows, making them notoriously unreliable for organizers. PlayLocal's check-in and Reliability Score directly solve this pain point.
 2. **No Purpose-Built Trust System:** These platforms have no integrated concept of reliability. A user's profile is generic and provides no context for their behavior in a sports setting.
 3. **Ineffective Safety Tools:** Moderation is entirely manual. They lack specific, built-in features like a "Women-Only" game filter or a discreet reporting system tailored to on-the-field issues, making it difficult for organizers to create and maintain safe, inclusive spaces.

Description of Customer and Company

After evaluating Professor Rigby's recommendations, we have pivoted to PlayLocal, a self-stakeholding startup focused on solving the fundamental social challenges of pickup sports. The project will promote an active, healthy lifestyle by fostering opportunities to meet new people in a safe and reliable environment. To validate the problem and our MVP loop, we will conduct 8–12 short interviews early in the term with active pickup-sports players/organizers and

run a small pilot later to measure fill rate and no-show rate. For user feedback, our MVP will focus on validating the core loop of game creation, organizer-confirmed attendance, and the post-game reputation process. We will collect analytics on join rates, retention, no-show rates, and the usage of our reputation features to iterate and refine the system.